Varma's illustrious legacy, particularly his granddaughter–Maharani Sethu Lakshmi Bayi–the last ruling queen of the erstwhile Travancore kingdom," says Gitanjali Maini, the foundation's CEO.

This art show has on display five oil-on-canvas artworks and photographs that cover the Maharani's life from her infancy to her reign, and then finally a quiet life in Bengaluru.

Conceptualised by the foundation with research and documentation by historian Manu S. Pillai, author of the award-winning *The Ivory Throne: Chronicles of the House of Travancore*, the centrepiece of the exhibition is a hitherto unseen original painting of the Maharani from the Travancore royal collection that depicts her as a three-year-old child painted by her grandfather Ravi Varma. "Legend has it that it was presented to her by Ravi Varma on the occasion of Onam after her coronation as the Maharani. The eyes and expression in this painting are unmistakably Ravi Varma's style, capturing a moment of amusement yet stoicism, embodying the qualities of a future Maharani," says Bharani Thirunal Rukmini Bayi Thampuran, chairperson of the foundation.

THE ART SHOW HAS ON DISPLAY FIVE OIL-ON-CANVAS ARTWORKS AND PHOTOS THAT COVER THE MAHARANI'S LIFE

Other paintings include one done in oil by Rukmini Bayi that depicts her grandmother–the Maharani–during her time as Regent. "Having known and cherished my grandmother deeply, I feel like I've infused her life essence into this piece and I'm delighted that it is now with Gitanjali," she adds.

While the focus of the foundation is on the documentation and preservation of Ravi Varma's work, Maini says they often come across paintings done by the artist that have never been seen, researched, documented or published before. They continually work with collectors or public and private museums that house or own works by this incredible artist. "Therefore, it becomes the responsibility of the foundation that such paintings are talked about and displayed for the world to see," reiterates Maini.

Are there plans to take this one-of-a-kind exhibition to other cities? "We are definitely considering showcasing the event in other cities like Mumbai and Delhi," says Mani. Exhibitions further afield, in Singapore and elsewhere are also being considered." ■

–Geetika Sachdev





RAJA RAVI VARMA
An Everlasting Imprint
by Ganesh V. Shivaswamy
WHITE FALCON PUBLISHING

Vol. 1: The Shaping of an Artist; **₹4,750**; **352** pages

Vol. 2: A Resonant Impression; **₹4,550**; **320** pages

Vol. 3: A Divine Omnipresence; **₹4,750**; **348** pages

a look at the act of painting itself, with the fashionable and progressive European consciousness of perspective, shadow, posture and landscape creating a new genre. Perhaps the most important aspect of Raja Ravi Varma was how Dadabhai Naoroji convinced him to open a press in his own name, discontinuing the Chitrashala Press in Pune. With this, his paintings reached the public with a snowballing geometric progression of praise and purchase, a visual virus of the early 20th century, so to say, which consumed all elements of society by the sheer magic of lustrous prints married to the raging industrial revolution. This was the chromolithographic Ravi Varma Press which influenced the essence of Indian attire in theatre, cinema and even the high society of the times, to define the everlasting pan–Indian image of us, the Indians. While the royal patrons commissioned oil paintings, the glistening chromolithographs rolled off the printing press to reach every domestic shrine within reach. This whole process was possible, as the author explains, because the picture was the protagonist, not the artist. The pictures of Raja Ravi Varma, which hold the popular imagination while the artist waltzes in and out of this art scenario for critics, were nothing short of a visual revolution.

Shivaswamy does not approach the artist in any hagiographic or deferential manner. He tries to be as analytical and objective as possible, and his mind understands where to engage with the artist with respect and where to criticise him, and to join those who may have written of him only in praise, such as Coomaraswamy and Chawla. But he also agrees with the critics like Smith and Pearson, where they are reasonable, because Ravi Varma was a painter, not a God. ■

–Aman Nath